

should not gratuitously deform the document.

On the other hand, which browser I use does not affect anyone else.

In the following sections I will discuss the Linux applications I use that correspond to Word, Excel, Outlook and Lync. I'll also discuss browsers.

The desktop

You need to understand a little about what my desktop runs to make sense of the sections that follow. I'm not recommending my choices, just providing context. For most readers, Ubuntu might provide a more familiar experience.

I always find that the Microsoft environment messes with my head. There is nothing I want less, nothing that would put me off more, than a Linux option which offered the Microsoft look and feel. But that's just me. I'm not trying to convert anyone.

Currently, my machine at work runs CentOS 5.7. It also runs Fedora 16 under VMware Player (with Fedora as a virtual machine). CentOS gives me a conservative and stable platform for most of my work, but I also have access to reasonably leading-edge software under Fedora. To me, it feels like I'm running two computers, with some of my sessions in CentOS and others in Fedora.

It is unlikely that any of my readers use the windowing system I do, or have even heard of it: OLVM (OPEN LOOK Virtual Window Manager). It has a look and feel that I have grown comfortable with over 10 years, and I see no point in changing. Fortunately, my choice of windowing system does not prevent you from running your preference.

Office products

For a near equivalent to Word or Excel, I use LibreOffice, a descendant of OpenOffice. "How near?" I hear you ask. Well, I have had no complaints. I don't know how well LibreOffice handles Excel macros, but for the sort of spreadsheets I encounter, LibreOffice's Calc module is excellent. For Word documents, LibreOffice's Writer suits me, but I am more interested in content than presentation.

Importantly, LibreOffice lets you open Word and Excel documents, and to view them the way they were intended to look, or pretty close to it. If your work requires you to produce or work with Word documents where the presentation must be exactly right, Writer may not be for you. It's possible that things have changed, but over many years, OpenOffice has often disappointed users when it came to the fine details. In which case, you might not be able to get away from Microsoft altogether. You might prefer to run XP as a virtual machine, and use Microsoft Word and Excel.

LibreOffice is readily available on Fedora. It is not available in standard YUM repositories in CentOS 5.7. It might be possible to get it to run, but I fear that it would jeopardise stability, so I'm not prepared to try. The URL is

www.documentfoundation.org/develop Install the LibreOffice spreadsheet application with *yum install libreoffice-calc*.

The total download size is 142 M, and the installed size is 417 M. Install the LibreOffice word processor application with *yum install libreoffice-writer*. The total download size is 86 M.

Email

Many sites use Microsoft Exchange as the mail server, with users running Outlook as their mail client. I've not tried it myself, but I believe Evolution provides compatibility with Exchange. You could also use OWA (a.k.a. Outlook Web Access), the Web interface to Outlook. For this, all you need is a browser. My solution is a combination. I use NMH (new MH message system) as my main email client. From Firefox, I use OWA to preview mail and to access calendars.

NMH (savannah.nongnu.org/projects/nmh) is an email system based on MH and is intended to be a (mostly) compatible drop-in replacement for MH. NMH isn't a single comprehensive program. Instead, it consists of a number of fairly simple single-purpose programs for sending, receiving, saving, retrieving and otherwise manipulating email messages. You can freely intersperse *nmh* commands with other shell commands, or write custom scripts that use *nmh* commands. If you want to use *nmh* as a true email user agent, you'll need to also install *exmh* to provide a user interface for it—*nmh* only has a command-line interface. Install it with *yum install nmh*. The total download size is 862 k, and installed size is 4.2 M.

In the unlikely event that you want to use NMH, you'll need *getmail* to retrieve messages from Exchange using IMAP. Getmail (pyropus.ca/software/getmail/) is intended as a simple replacement for Fetchmail for those who do not need its sundry configuration options, complexities and bugs. It retrieves mail from one or more POP3 servers for one or more email accounts, and reliably delivers into a Maildir specified on a per-account basis. It can also deliver into mbox files, although this should not be attempted over NFS. Getmail is written entirely in Python. Install it with *yum install getmail*. The total download size is 174 k, while the installed size is 838 k.

Don't let the description of Getmail put you off. I don't think the maintainers have changed it in years. In that time, IMAP4 and, presumably, other features have been added to it.

Browsers

This one is easy. Some rather annoying websites seem to go out of their way to only work perfectly with Internet Explorer, but even dedicated Microsoft users sometimes prefer Firefox or Chrome. Mozilla Firefox (www.mozilla.org/projects/firefox/) is an open source Web browser, designed for standards compliance, performance and portability. I have run Firefox for a long time, so I usually run at least one Firefox at work—in my CentOS environment. That means it's getting a bit long in the tooth, but it's more than adequate for the bulk